their positions. Manipur has emerged as the country's most improved small state for the third consecutive time. This consistency stems from the state's improved performance in eight out of 12 categories—economy, infrastructure, agriculture, health, governance, entrepreneurship, tourism and cleanliness—in the past five years. While it tops the small states in economy, infrastructure and entrepreneurship, Manipur figures among the top three in three categories—health, governance and tourism.

Chief Minister N. Biren Singh credits this to the period of peace in the past four years, free of frequent terror attacks, ethnic conflicts or economic blockade. Once, these blockades, imposed by a variety of organisations and continuing for months, paralysed Manipur, drastically pushing up prices of essential commodities, while the government remained a mute spectator. Barring a couple of incidents in 2021, a pre-election year, the number of terror-related killings has dropped from more than 55 in 2017 to just seven this year.

You can tell on the street what the atmosphere of relative peace has brought to Manipur. People can be seen strolling around public places after 9 pm, even in capital Imphal, where shops shut almost after sundown. Evening walkers throng the new riverfront park, illuminated in colourful lights, while youngsters hang out on rooftop cafes with a guitar. "My immediate priority was to bring peace and political stability," says Biren Singh. "Once that was achieved, people had the confidence in the government and then together we have embarked on a developmental journey."

CM Singh believes his past experience as a journalist and footballer has stood him in good stead. "As a journalist, I was always looking for the truth, which made me aware of the primary cause of every problem in the state," he says. "And, a sportsperson always looks for results. So when I became a politician, I already knew where the problems were and my sports-man spirit helped me focus on results, which is the deliverance of public good."

TOP PERFORMERS IN MOST IMPROVED CATEGORY

RANK	STATE	APPEARANCES IN TOP 5* (2018-2022)
1	MANIPUR	45
2	MIZORAM	41
3	NAGALAND	37
4	ARUNACHAL PRADESH	34
5	MEGHALAYA	33
5	SIKKIM	33

*across the 12 categories

IT'S A HAT TRICK FOR MANIPUR THIS YEAR AS MOST IMPROVED STATE, TOPPING 8 OUT OF 12 CATEGORIES

Shortly after taking charge, the Manipur CM started holding a public durbar at his official residence on the 15th of every month to get a measure of people's grievances first-hand. Soon, however, he felt that it was more important for the government to go to the people, particularly those living in remote areas and feeling marginalised. That sentiment translated into Singh's 'Go to Hills' mission, an outreach to the hill tribes. The lack of communication and misunderstanding between the hill tribes and the ethnic groups in Imphal Valley, coupled with political apathy and manoeuvring, has erupted in violent conflicts and insurgency, holding economic progress hostage.

Constantly conscious of maintaining a balance, the CM launched another mission in November 2021. Christened 'Go to Village', it intends to cover the population in the Valley. "Both missions helped me go into the roots of the mistrust between different communities and the causes of uneven socio-economic progress in different parts of the state," says Singh. The Naga community, for instance, had long complained that, unlike in the Valley, there was no arrangement for an Ima market—a market run exclusively by women—in the hills. Taking heed of this grievance, the Singh government began building the infrastructure for an Ima market in all the hill districts.

Thanks to the mass connect vehicles such as the public durbar and the two go-to missions, the government could also ascertain the gaps and loopholes in the delivery of services. Building on that ground information, the execution of government schemes and projects was strengthened even as feedback on improvements kept coming intermittently via these outreach programmes. "The key to development is minute-to-minute monitoring," says the chief minister. Also making a difference was the CM's accessibility, and thinking nothing of directly responding to public queries through WhatsApp and social media platforms.

Manipur's journey thus far is indeed creditworthy, but by no means over. Despite its progress, it's still among the lowest performers on multiple parameters. Its improvements on development indices are often magnified because of the low base they start from. What is considered normal in other parts of the country—say, a safe stroll in the city in the evening—is cherished as an achievement here. But having taken a leap to the new normal, Manipur needs to sustain its progress in the long run. And on its own, not with heavy assistance from the Centre. ■